infrastructure, including social infrastructure projects. However, the 2015 Amendment Bill, brought for this purpose, could not get through the Rajya Sabha and the government abandoned the effort. A lot of irreparable damage has already been done. Urbanization, industrialization and infrastructure building have collapsed. Capital expenditure is constantly coming down and infrastructure in the private sector has become a casualty.

The situation has to change. A balance between the interests of landowners and purchasers has to be restored. Land has to become freely available for industrialization and infrastructure building. This is necessary to build a $10 trillion economy.

Two fundamental reforms are required in the 2013 Law:

First, the applicability of the law needs to be severely limited. It should only be used for projects that require land for the government to produce public goods and services. Defence, policing, health, regulation, etc., should be the purposes for which land could be ‘acquired’. The 2013 Law extends the liability to provide for a relief and rehabilitation package even for purely private purchase of land through private negotiations if the land involved is more than the limit prescribed by the government. These provisions need to be dropped. For private projects, the acquisition law should be used only where the private entrepreneur is able to buy more than 80 per cent of the land by private negotiations but some minority landowners are unjustifiably holding up the remaining land. In such a situation, the Law should be used just to determine a reasonable price.

Second, all the confusions and contradictions of the 2013 Law should be sorted out. The environmental and social impact consideration should be made applicable to the project, not the land acquisition. The price paid for land should be related to the market price plus compensation. If the underlying market price is not reflective of true price, the same should be objectively determined by the acquisition officer. Other interests in the land